Cover Letter

Dear Reader,

Thank you for taking the time to read my portfolio for WRT102. Throughout the semester, I've learned a lot from taking this writing course. After thorough revision of my writing, I can say that I have grown as a writer, and I will demonstrate the knowledge and skills I developed in the process of each assignment. Through the course, there were biweekly assigned reading articles, a research-based essay, and finally a letter to incoming freshmen to help "Navigate through Academia".

After developing my reading skills through the intensive reading responses, I began to work on the first assignment: a research-based argumentative essay. I found this essay to be more challenging than I expected, and working on it was a time-consuming process that required critical thinking to develop. In this essay, I formed my position on the use of AI to conserve energy usage in the context of environmental issues. I decided to focus on this subject because I have an interest in both energy sources and computer science. These topics are intertwined with the present issue of artificial intelligence, and I wanted to understand more about the impact being made when using it. This logical argument was formed from extensive research and annotations done from trustworthy sources using the available databases that were introduced to us. In addition, I also peer-reviewed other essays across different topics to improve my writing and formatting by understanding ideas and writing styles from other scholars.

In the next essay, I wrote about how students could navigate through academia. In my personal experience, I found that the most impactful contribution to my belonging in the Stony Brook community was through connecting with friends and faculty by writing. It was also an opportunity to gain some insight into how others felt through the first year in college. I found that this reflective experience was an essay more enjoyable to write than the research-based essay. The sources I referenced through the essay were also reading assignments, such as those written by authors Jo-Anne Kerr, Robert Yagelski, Terrel Strayhorn, Ashley Ritter, and Steve Marshal. We also discussed the reading assignments in class, which gave me a greater comprehension of the articles and allowed me to improve my engagement with the sources in my essay. After engaging with the text, I connected it back to how the reader may also engage in a similar experience in college and the similar experiences I faced in the studies mentioned within each article.

In my reflection on the WRT102 course, I find that I enjoy writing more often and using it as a powerful skill, polished through the semester, which has been helpful to me in conveying ideas and communicating with others. In the future, I'll continue to write and improve my formatting and literacy. Thank you again for taking the time to read my WRT102 portfolio.

Sincerely,
Matthew Kuan

Research Paper

Matthew Kuan

Dr. Shyam Sharma

WRT 102: Intermediate College Writing

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Could AI be More Beneficial Than Harmful for the Environment?

Technological advancements have led to artificial intelligence becoming a widespread global technology for many purposes in the present day. Some examples that may come to mind are in education, healthcare, navigation, finance, social media, and entertainment. As artificial intelligence's public implementation accelerates, an issue arises: the enormous energy usage necessary to support the AI runtime. This is significant because increased global warming and resource usage result from the energy production needed to sustain AI's electricity usage. The constant use of artificial intelligence harms the environment as it requires a lot of processing power, raising concerns in the world as more effort is put into developing training machine learning databases. However, AI should be considered as a powerful technology that can help combat the explosion of energy usage in the world. In this essay, I invite you to an assessment of how AI could be a solution to energy overuse, showing that it can be useful in reducing environmental harm because of its contributions towards reducing global energy usage, finding greater alternative renewable energy sources, and efficiently implementing energy plants.

The rising energy demand continues to be a pressing issue, and there is an extent to which our population will be able to provide for this energy. This growing population's AI usage is why it is necessary to develop solutions for energy reduction instead of disregarding the waste produced as a byproduct of AI energy usage. The **conservation** of energy is essential to further develop because demand continues to grow for electricity in the world as the population increases. In addition, as Blakers, a Professor of Engineering with high involvement in environmental research, underscores the growing need for renewable energy with population increase as "affluence is increasing, and it is probable that much of the fossil fuels used for motor transport, heating, and industry" (322). This conveys the issue that growing populations will result in more technology use, and AI's accelerated growth in public usage has made energy consumption an issue greater than ever. This problem requires a switch from fossil fuels to electricity from low-emission sources such as wind energy, which AI helps adopt and manage. Although AI usage to implement renewable energies may not seem like the first solution that comes to mind, Blaker's remarks establish that finding alternatives that emit low carbon will continue to be implemented in the world as they help make the Earth last longer and reduce global warming. In addition, countries with large populations, such as India, are expected to use a lot of electricity as predicted by Das, a Programme Manager for Renewable Energy from the Centre for Science and Environment, "to grow between 6–7 percent every year over the next decade" (Das 10). As large populations accelerate in size, the use of electricity is an important issue to address. A solution to reduce global energy consumption ethically is to utilize the specific energy sources that are most environmentally friendly. An example is wind energy, which is available for some specific regions that have a lot of free space.

There are many alternatives in the world to Energy conservation that are being implemented across different countries to address the pressing issue of energy consumption; with AI, countries' efforts to reduce energy usage could be further amplified. Artificial intelligence can be used to statistically optimize and moderate current energy production sites in order to promote the implementation of renewable energy. Countries with large spaces suitable for wind energy have installed wind turbines as an alternative to fossil fuels, reducing their production of greenhouse gases (Das 17). Therefore, areas that have the potential to implement renewable energy will begin to take action as AI can assess energy source adoptions, such as wind turbines. With AI's ability to quantify the offshore wind capacity and other features nearby, it can make a rationale for the installation (Butrache and Stancu 13). For instance, the water necessary to cool down computing devices could be contaminated by the corrosive material in the installation process. Thus, for the installation of wind turbines, data needs to be collected on the surrounding environment. Wind turbines are large technological devices that can still pose damage to the surroundings with their presence. A method for observing the surrounding areas is to take note of average wind speeds, an essential characteristic that would be necessary; geotechnical conditions, necessary for the design of the foundation and customization of wind turbines; infrastructure, and coastal area, as biodiversity and fishing could be impacted. In addition, the economics of the country also play a large role as a deciding factor in the installation of wind turbines because they require large components and labor to set up. Anything can affect the development of wind turbines, as it is dependent on how it is built, according to the area around it, which would affect the price. Additionally, like everything developed in the world, machines can corrode, which also harms the environment, so maintenance is required and, depending on location, could be costly. Many factors are considered, so it is more convenient and cost-effective to remotely take observations of the data, which AI could help do. A capability that machine learning has is the ability to identify patterns when given data of multiple variables (Baturache and Stancu 7). This pattern recognition that AI does allows it to fundamentally enable more wind turbines to be built, which allows a greater change from the use of carbon-based fuels to renewable energy. Furthermore, the prediction of energy production facilitates the adoption of wind energy on an even larger scale than is presently possible (Butaruche & Stancu 32). In addition, In Dac's research article, where he analyzed the market trends in renewable energy sources, there was a noticeable "drop in the cost of offshore wind energy, especially in mature European markets, and a favorable strike price for offshore wind compared to electricity generated from nuclear power plants, making it 37 percent cheaper than nuclear energy" (Dac 23). A decline in wind energy prices also makes it more likely to be implemented as a preferred renewable energy source. All of these collective factors make AI more desirable as a result of its efficiency in problem-solving, to further implement more renewable energy sources. Using this predictability from AI models could help push for wind energy, which facilitates greenhouse gases to lower emissions. The use of AI systems to monitor and maintain systems for machines or living spaces could reduce energy use. This addition to learning how different energy sources could be preferred in the world, and in a forward-thinking world, leans towards renewable energy sources. In addition, when AI facilitates the installation of renewable energy, more people would be willing to shift towards the new renewable energy, which is overall better for the environment. The shift to meet energy conservation goals requires much investment in emerging markets and developing economies (IEA 3). In addition, an economic benefit arises when the job market grows. The goal of AI, when made intending to support the environment, is to make "[i]mprovements in electricity generation capacity, stability, and predictability of operating mode are carefully pursued with the hope of achieving the most efficient integration and easing the transition from traditional to renewable energy resources" (Baturache and Stancu 18). AI usage makes ecosystem analysis more efficient when trained correctly. Thus, AI has a positive impact on the quality of the environment when its computational power is directed towards helping renewable energy be implemented.

AI makes a positive contribution towards reducing climate change via the computational programs designed to specifically break down the components of wind installation and identify patterns. An example case study includes the use of “SVR, RT, RF, and ANNs [] selected for predicting wind energy production. An optimization for the number of folds, k¸ used for cross-validation was performed. Considering the performance and the training time, the selected value for k was equal to 3” (Baturache and Stancu 4). These methods of computational algorithms are less computationally demanding than machine learning specifically, but they can still be effective in implementing renewable energy sources. This result is useful to environmental health because it allows organizations installing wind turbines to know the most important factors in determining which locations are best to install. After thorough data analysis from the collected information of the installation site, researchers will know “whether the available data are of the right quality and quantity to continue the project” (Baturache and Stancu 13-14). When considering different locations to place wind turbines, AI could accelerate the decision-making process as it confirms the suitability of the area to install. With AI technology, future projects could be further developed according to precise guidelines, and when properly done, “ANNs can deliver accurate predictions for forecasting wind energy production but carry costs associated with the resources, time, and computational power required to find the optimum hyperparameter combination” (Baturache and Stancu 17). A machine learning model, such as principal component analysis, simplifies the different issues in the environment and tells us the main issues that must be solved first. To add on, conserve energy and combat climate change by helping integrate wind and solar energy. Olusegun Samuel Ojuekaiye, an ROV supervisor from the Northern Marine Manning Ship Management, notes in his case study analysis for AI use in offshore wind energy, where he observed “reduced downtime, increased efficiency, and cost savings," and additional positive outcomes when AI-driven grids are used to analyze real-time data from weather patterns, consumer behavior, and industrial usage to optimize distribution (Ojuekaiye 17-20). This demonstrates how machine learning models algorithms are used to predict the weather in the long term, which will allow for better installation and data analysis of energy sources like wind turbines and make scheduling more efficient. In a research article published in the *Journal of Low Carbon Economy*, titled "Wind Energy Prediction Using Machine Learning," Adrian-Nicole Baturache and Stelian Stancu introduce their case study where Google's AI, Deepmind, acts as a recommendation system in moderating building temperatures. The result of this use of AI caused a "40% reduction in the energy used for cooling" (2). Scholars at the Economic Cybernetics Department of Bucharest University of Economic Studies, the authors, demonstrate with their research the benefits that AI has in reducing energy usage, as it cuts down nearly half the energy in an entire building. With Google's implementation of AI technology from Bataurache and Stancu's case study, the technology industry would reduce its energy consumption by nearly half in the building.

Consumer	Renewable energy consumption
China	22%
Germany	40%
United States	17%
Amazon AWS	50%
Google†	100%
Microsoft	50%

Table 1: Percent renewable energy (e.g. hydroelectric, solar, wind) for the top 3 cloud compute providers compared to the United States, China, and Germany. Country percentages taken from Strubell, Ganesh, and McCallum (2019), while corporate numbers have been updated to the latest available information. † indicates that this includes purchases of renewable used to offset non-renewable energy used at locations and times where renewable energy is unavailable.

The table presented by Strubell, a scientist at Facebook AI Research, indicates Google and other companies have shifted towards renewable energy. With AI such as Deepmind that saves energy, industries will reduce their carbon emissions further because they've resorted to renewable energy. This makes AI vital in keeping up with the global population growth, as more and more people use more energy in a technologically advancing world. An additional positive impact that can be made is that energy consumption can be reduced by using AI to optimize systems and determine which ones to implement. Instead of choosing just one singular energy source, variable renewable energy systems can be a solution that provides a more inclusive view of the possible technologies. In Kalaivani's models, in the Department of Electrical and Electronics Engineering, Sri Manakula Vinayagar Engineering College, it is also mathematically and quantitatively understood how we are able to understand a way to optimize the various energy sources and their effectiveness. According to Kalaivani, this approach would be more beneficial as it "improve[s] flexibility and decrease[s] the total cost of system" (Kalaivani 6). This effectiveness relies on breaking down each potential technology into its different components. Using this model, machine learning will, in a similar method, analyze the principal renewable energies that should be installed. With Artificial Intelligence, it can be made easier to differentiate the different types of energies and computationally find the most optimal configurations in managing all the types of energy sources. For example, wind energy is affected by the velocity of the wind, the length of the blades, etc. Furthermore, energy usage can also be quantified through mathematical relationships as Kalaivani states "Based on the demand of power and variation of variable renewable energy generation like PV and WT, the necessary flexibility is calculated" (11). This program developed also offers a method called the white shark optimizer and pelican optimization algorithm to help understand the efficiency of each energy source and visualize it through graphing around systems. Kalavnai's research demonstrates that with a strong computational device, like AI, and proper techniques in data analysis it could be easier to predict important environmentally friendly systems. It makes comparing and optimizing all the different energy sources more efficient, and the usage of computational models in weighing the pros and cons for people makes it easier to determine the optimal choices. At times, it might be good to have a mix of various sustainable energy sources and to minimize the usage of energy to avoid resorting to harmful methods.

A main contributing factor that makes Artificial Intelligence so dangerous to the environment is the raw processing power that is required to initially set up this technology to become useful. Lacoste, a research scientist at Element AI, developed a calculator for the carbon footprint of users in Google, Amazon, and Microsoft cloud resources. Furthermore, Strubell developed the idea that when machine learning researchers analyzed data collected from this tool, it could be understood that the geographical connection between users and their usage of energy in carbon emissions (Strubell 4). Machine learning models must first be fed data to make them reliable and draw conclusions across different important resources. Energy is a necessity to make the training process smooth, and it could be harmful if there is no strong system around it to maintain the devices used for AI.

Model	Hardware	Power (W)	Hours	kWh·PUE	CO_2e	Cloud compute cost
$T2T_{base}$	P100x8	1415.78	12	27	13	$41–$140
$T2T_{big}$	P100x8	1515.43	84	201	96	$289–$981
ELMo	P100x3	517.66	336	275	131	$433–$1472
$BERT_{base}$	V100x64	12,041.51	79	1507	719	$3751–$12,571
$BERT_{base}$	TPUv2x16	—	96	—	—	$2074–$6912
NAS	P100x8	1515.43	274,120	656,347	313,078	$942,973–$3,201,722
NAS	TPUv2x1	—	32,623	—	—	$44,055–$146,848
GPT-2	TPUv3x32	—	168	—	—	$12,902–$43,008

Table 2: Estimated cost of training a model in terms of CO_2 emissions (lbs) and cloud compute cost (USD) (Strubell, Ganesh, and McCallum 2019). Power and carbon footprint are omitted for TPUs due to lack of public information on power draw.

This table of data from Strubell suggests that the financial and energy cost of training machine learning software is a large drawback to using artificial intelligence in general. Many issues arise when considering AI as a platform for data in the environment. Walther, a scholar at the Wharton AI Analytics Initiative and director of POZE (Perspective, Optimization, Zenith, and Exposure), states

> Training large language models like GPT-4 demands immense computational resources. Recent research shows that training GPT-3 consumed approximately 1,287 megawatt-hours (MWh) of electricity, emitting 502 metric tons of CO_2 … Beyond the energy demands for training and usage, the infrastructure required for bringing AI systems to scale strains the planet's natural resources, especially water. Data centers, which power AI models, use vast amounts of water for cooling. According to recent estimates, the average data center uses 1.7 liters of water per kilowatt-hour of energy consumed. As AI becomes more integrated into everyday business operations, the increasing demand for water places additional stress on already scarce resources. While the tech industry tends to emphasize the benefits of AI, including its potential to devise creative solutions to address and alleviate climate change, it is time to also account for the hidden costs of our algorithmic affinity, which directly affect our ecosystems and have consequences that have begun to manifest. (Walther)

In this article, Walther asserts that energy consumption for training AI models contributes to carbon emissions and water usage. An important aspect is that AI has its efficiency and speed once it is done being trained. The computational power it has could accurately provide important data on landscapes with accurate data. However, as it continues to be used and made with small variations across companies, "AI's hunger for electricity puts additional pressure on energy grids" (Walther). AI does come with many risks in the modern day, as it drains a lot of energy to sustain itself. It also puts stress on the water supplies as it is necessary to cool down data centers at around "1.7 liters of water per kilowatt-hour of energy consumed" (Walther). It is important to develop ways AI can be used in a way where it is not completely relied on, and perform computations more efficiently. As AI technology progresses, it can be developed to a point where it fits with our needs for addressing the environmental change everyone worries about. As stated by the University of College London Press, the establishment of technological landscapes acts as an intermediary between humans and nature to provide the remolding of landscapes for human needs (Agar 6). This demonstrates the strong relationship that the land has with energy usage, which is supported earlier by the specific requirements in installing certain technologies that offer alternative forms of sustainable energy. Another concept Agar introduces in his work is "artificial and the natural are not separate; technologies are made from materials that have been extracted and modified from environments, while nature has, to varying extents, been engineered" (1). The environment and technology will always be considered intertwined, as both are necessary for living organisms.

> A technological system usually has an environment consisting of intractable factors, not under the control of system managers, but these are not all organizational. If a factor in the environment – say, a supply of energy – should come under the control of the system, it is then an interacting part of it. Over time, technological systems manage increasingly to incorporate the environment into the system, thereby eliminating sources of uncertainty. (Hughes 53)

Hughes, a distinguished visiting professor at MIT in the field of History of Technology, remarks that when technological advancements such as AI make it so that in our society, newer generations have a stronger aptitude for using technology. This increasing inattention makes it so that sustainable energy sources are not as relevant in the public eye. However, contributions to the world are still being made to address environmental concerns. According to Williams, a professor at Stetson University, “Without doubt, the topic of climate change, which every nation in the world is (or should be) addressing, should prod members of [International Committee for the History of Technology] to deepen their efforts to explore energy, environmental and related technological subjects” (Williams 120). With technology, sustainable energy sources are made, and it is much easier to make change occur faster with social media or other platforms to convey concern for energy and the environment. While there are many consequences of AI on the environment, its convenience and power can be used to improve the technologies we use in the world that help improve outcomes in reusable energy production and reduce energy consumption.

Artificial Intelligence has proven itself to have the potential to reduce global energy usage. The use of AI further reduces energy usage in buildings and facilitates the installation of renewable energies, along with its limitations. Although widespread AI usage has benefit many, it should still be accountable for its contribution to global energy consumption, and setting up regulations for the usage and training of AI systems will push for more efficient development of software. As they continue to develop, they will be more efficient in managing energy usage, such as how Deepseek is more efficient than other AI tools because it consumes less computational power than other programs while providing better responses. When the environmental harm done by AI technology becomes insignificant compared to the energy produced and conserved, it would be very beneficial to implement AI across the world in an ethically responsible manner.

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Navigating Academia Essay

From: Matthew
To: Incoming Seawolves
Subject: Belonging in College

Dear Fellow Seawolves,
I hope this email finds you well. Congratulations on making it through the college admissions process and starting this chapter of your life. Transitioning from high school to college can be difficult and overwhelming. However, it doesn't always stay that way, and I'll be able to give you some advice from my experiences as an upcoming sophomore at Stony Brook. In the essay attached, I hope you can find your place in college and overcome any challenges that come your way.

Best regards,
Matthew Kuan

ATTACHMENT

Initially, maybe like how you could be feeling as you read this, I was hesitant in my choice of Stony Brook. I felt very uncertain — "Would I have a good fit? What if I went to a different school? Am I really following the right path?" These types of questions I'd ponder about late at night, and sometimes I still do. However, in my short 28 weeks spent in Stony Brook, I have come to find it to be a welcoming place I can be proud to stay at. In high school, classes were somewhat rigorous, but not in the same way as college challenges students. I remember in my AP Literature Class the constant reading assignments, analysis, and discussions in text. They definitely did improve my writing skills and made me a better reader, too, but there were also other "genres" of writing I hadn't yet explored until I got here. These genres I'm referring to are from an article we read in class that I'll explain a little more later in the essay.

For some context, I'll introduce myself: a freshman at Stony Brook University pursuing a Biomedical Engineering degree on the pre-med track. Although I dreaded taking a writing class, it was an inevitable part of the curriculum I had to face. However, WRT102 is a class that has helped me develop my sense of belonging here at Stony Brook. In this text, our class was assigned to read a textbook chapter titled "Why We Write" by Yagelski. It was one of the first few assignments we had, and the way our professor passionately explained the article sparked my understanding of writing: to explore oneself along with the professional, social, and academic uses. The relationship between professors and students is a little different in college, especially in general intro classes filled with hundreds of freshmen. A way that I've gotten by here was using writing to reach out to faculty and get the support I need to navigate through college. For instance, earlier this week, I was picking out classes for the next semester. I was a little lost and confused with the huge database of classes, so I went to email my course director, something along the lines of: *"I'm a freshman pre-med student and I'd like to go over the course registration schedule for the upcoming semester. Is there an available time I can meet with you?"*

Of course, she was happy to help, and even though I didn't get all the classes I wanted, I was able to plan for the rest of my undergrad here. In this example, writing was a powerful tool for me to get the help I needed in communicating with my advisor. I found writing to be involved in my everyday life, whether it's sending out emails, doing proofs, researching, or writing for assignments. Right now, I am writing. Writing is a tedious process, but it's an activity that can help one learn and connect.

I've found that professors are willing to help, and taking advantage of those opportunities to learn from and review material is an important part of navigating through college. In the course syllabus of one of the previous Calculus III classes at Stony Brook, the syllabus had something labeled "Tips for Learning Math." Some advice that I've taken from this message that Professor Romney wrote was this:

> Don't be afraid to think at a slower pace than your peers. If a classmate seems to grasp something faster than you, there is a high chance that it's just because they've already encountered a similar idea before. Don't confuse a slower pace with a lack of intelligence.

Although most of the text Professor Romney wrote was about learning math, I found it to be pretty helpful in all academic settings. My MAT 203 class had felt particularly stressful at that time, and my performance on the midterm felt a little discouraging. However, as I was reading it, I felt a little more at ease and took this letter as motivation. Letters like these, written to help guide students through college, are one of the many things that have helped me get by in my classes. Although there will always be large hurdles in life, there is a community here that has helped me to overcome these problems. Even when they are not directly helping, they could be announcing an office hours time hosted by their TAs on Brightspace. I found that there was always someone to help me across academics and belonging; I just had to put in the effort of asking around and reaching out to professors, faculty, and my peers on campus. Literacy has impacted my sense of belonging, and this fundamental need is related to many factors. You may have concerns about making friends, interacting with peers, roommates, and faculty, all the while maintaining a high GPA, like those in a study of the academic literacy course in Vancouver, Canada (Marshall et al.). In their mixed-method study of surveying students and their writing samples related to belonging, many students questioned their belonging and did not truly feel accepted initially in college. I found myself relating to the challenges they faced, yet I was able to overcome them, and I realized I wasn't struggling alone..

Academics could be a big challenge, but once the semester is over, I feel a sense of relief and feel like I truly learned something. In this article we read, "Novice as Experts," the author talks about how freshmen were able to simultaneously grow and challenge themselves in their writing. An essay can be difficult to write and organize thoughts into. However, it further deepens one's understanding of culture, religion, philosophy, etc. Writing my research-based essay forced me to engage with my sources in the strict MLA format. Through the writing process, I found the class and its assignments frustrating to complete. I spent many nights this semester restructuring my essay and researching, and there were so many ideas or concepts that had to be covered within the time we had to work on the essay. It was a very difficult experience for me, but at the end of it, like the students in the text, I felt that huge rush of pride for accomplishing the difficult task of essay writing. The writing process was both stressful and rewarding, as not only did it feel good to finish homework, but I could also learn from it and gain skills that can be applied to other subjects. It was a structure that I had to follow to strengthen my writing and improve my skills. Now, or when it's not an assignment at least, I enjoy writing and will engage in it more often than I remember myself before coming to college. Of course, science-based courses aren't as writing-intensive. However, they come with the necessity of understanding how to interpret textbooks and really demonstrating your knowledge through writing.

Belonging could also come from finding a community of people you can trust and spend time with. Similar to this article, our class read, by Jo-Anne Ker, I had grown my skills in writing to make my "disposition," or translatable skills and knowledge, more suitable for other classes and outside academics. My perspective in writing has expanded beyond just for the purpose of humanities schoolwork. I began to realize that I had spent some part of my time writing, every day: messaging friends and family about school, classes, and our interests was a way to destress. In my research class, my group and I had to go through a lot of medical publications to come up with our presentation. It was a way for us to connect through our understanding of the biological pathways we were exploring. Then, we would share different articles and expand on each other's thoughts by writing. As one writes, they're adding onto the research articles they've read and engaging with them to elicit their own beliefs in a topic. In a way, I've found it to be similar to a conversation in the sense that people are always involved and contributing different ideas. Writing is another form of communication, after all. This "essence of belonging," as stated by Strayhorn, another author of a reading we read, defines it as a basic human need of "students' perceived social support on campus …" in the context of college. He provided examples of different cases where students and he struggled to belong. But over time, they found their place by finding a supportive community. Finding my way through college to achieve this belonging has changed my approach in college to look forward to meeting new people.

Although what I've learned from WRT102 has helped me professionally and academically, I've gained some personal development as well in my life. Similar to the present, I've reflected a lot on my experience through writing. In the words of Ritter, I used "literacy" as a way of expression with freedom and creativity. This article in particular was something I felt personally connected to, and I think if you read it in the future, you will also have some connection to it. Ritter discusses how her writing experience in middle school and high school was full of strict rules that limited students from understanding different genres of writing. As she continued to grow as a writer, her use of literacy and word choice gave her confidence and purpose in writing. I've felt that I, too, am starting to develop that sense of assurance through language. Nightly journaling, for example, was a way for me to reflect on my day or week and express my thoughts. I found my belonging here at Stony Brook, and the value I hold in this community is something I cherish. Writing has made me belong, and belonging has made me a better writer, performing academically.

In the near future, I hope to use what I've learned from this course to further myself in other fields of school and career. A challenge that I've faced throughout life was finding the right words to convey my thoughts, but over time, my literacy has developed, and I find myself not struggling as much to think of how I should be saying something. Now, I am able to write this essay to you with more confidence and deliver my (almost) one-year experience in Stony Brook to you in a way that should be digestible.

Thank you for making it this far into the essay, and I hope you found it helpful to read about my experiences and reflection. Even if you still don't quite get college yet, I know you will eventually find your place of belonging in university. I wish you the best of luck in your academic journey.

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